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Dear Members of the Search Committee,

I am writing in strong support of Mengnan Xu's application for the Postdoctoral Fellowship at the Centre on Contemporary China and the World. I know Mengnan in two capacities: as her co-supervisor and dissertation committee member at Beijing Normal University, where I hold a position as Professor under China's High-Level Foreign Talents Programme, and as a direct research collaborator — we are co-authors on a paper published in the *Journal of Contemporary China* (2022, SSCI Q1). Through both relationships I have had ample opportunity to observe her as a scholar, and I recommend her with confidence and without qualification.

The paper we co-authored, "Poor and Lazy: Understanding Middle-Class Perceptions of Poverty in China," draws on survey data from a research programme on poverty perceptions and moral stigma in China, and Mengnan was involved across the full arc of the project — from questionnaire design and data collection through to the quantitative analysis. She applied binomial and multinomial logistic regression to relate poverty attribution patterns to psychological, sociological, and policy-related predictors. The analysis is technically rigorous, but what struck me most was the intellectual judgment she brought to interpreting the results: she understood from the outset that this was not merely a study of attitudes but a study of the political conditions that make redistributive anti-poverty policy difficult in China. That kind of analytical reach — from empirical patterns to structural implications — is not common at her career stage.

My supervisory relationship with Mengnan has given me a vantage point that extends beyond the published work. What I have observed over the arc of her doctoral research is a scholar who thinks independently under pressure: she does not defer to received frameworks when the evidence pushes elsewhere, and she pursues analytical problems with a persistence and intellectual honesty that is not common at her career stage. What strikes me equally is the depth of her commitment to academic work as a vocation. She has maintained a serious and cumulative research programme across significant institutional transitions and competing demands — that kind of sustained dedication, in my experience, is a more reliable predictor of scholarly achievement than any single paper or result. She is also among the most effective communicators of research I have worked with among junior scholars — precise in her language, alert to her audience, and able to hold the thread of a complex argument across a long seminar discussion. I have had further opportunity to observe these qualities through her role as teaching assistant for my graduate seminar on the frontiers of social development governance at Beijing Normal University. Her involvement went well beyond logistical support: she participated actively in discussion, helped students navigate the intersection of Chinese and international scholarship, and engaged with the material at the level of a collaborator. The bilingual intellectual environment of that seminar is a reasonable approximation of what a researcher

at CCCW will face daily — and Mengnan was entirely at home in it.

I should also note what Mengnan represents as a scholar working at an unusual disciplinary intersection. Her quantitative competence is considerable, but it operates in service of questions that are fundamentally about governance, ideology, and political economy — not simply about methods. The research she has conducted on the organisational ecology of China’s poverty alleviation implementation, and the computational pipelines she has developed to analyse governance documents at scale, extend the analytical logic of our collaborative work into the implementation domain: if the ideational conditions for redistribution shape political feasibility, then the organisational conditions for implementation shape actual outcomes. Taken together, her published work and her dissertation constitute a coherent research programme on China’s anti-poverty governance that is both empirically grounded and theoretically ambitious.

CCCW is a natural institutional home for that programme. The Centre’s focus on Chinese political leadership and governance, its investment in AI-assisted social science, and its position in Hong Kong — at once embedded in and analytically distanced from the mainland governance system — align with what Mengnan has been developing. I am confident that she will make a substantive contribution to the Centre’s research and that the fellowship period will be a productive one for both her and the institution.

In my experience of working with early-career scholars across multiple institutions and countries, Mengnan stands out for the combination of intellectual independence, methodological range, and genuine scholarly ambition she brings to her work. I recommend her to your fellowship without reservation.

Sincerely,

Robert Walker, Ph.D.

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